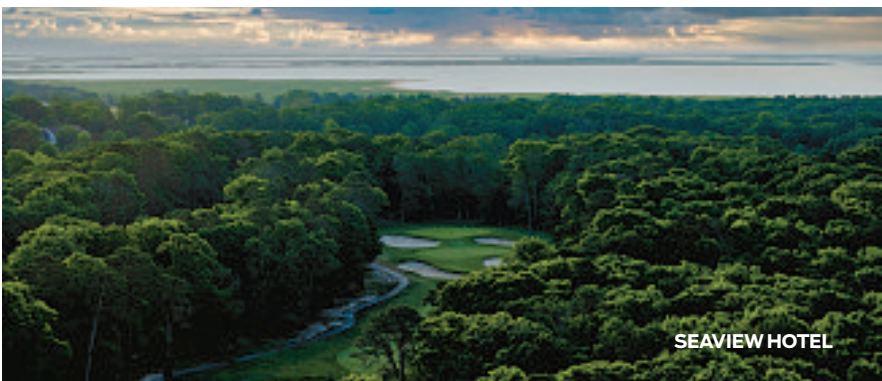


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SUNDAY, MAY 4, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

New mayor hopes to lead Arlington Park's rebirth

What closing the deal on a Bears stadium would represent

By Andrew Carter
Chicago Tribune

One week before his inauguration as the new mayor of Arlington Heights, Jim Tinaglia walked through the downtown streets he's called home for more than 50 years. What was once a "sleepy little town," as he described it, has become a bustling community, a place Tinaglia has had a hand in building, himself, through his work as an architect.

He'd built "at least a dozen" places here over the past 35 years. Banks. Restaurants.

"And that one," he said pointing across the street to the old general store that he'd helped turn into a popular tavern and grill. If there'd been a constant amid all the growth in one of Chicago's largest suburbs, it was probably the horse racing track a little ways northwest of downtown, the one now locked away and waiting for new life. For decades, Arlington Park had been a deeply-ingrained part of the culture here, and a source of pride.

"Our identity," Tinaglia said of the track. "For 100 years."

Now it will be his mission, when he's sworn in as mayor Monday, to lead Arlington Park's rebirth — to complete the long, winding journey of bringing the Chicago Bears to Arlington Heights. It's a large part of why he ran for mayor, and also why he believes he was elected: to finish a deal that has proven elusive since a rush of early momentum, and to help convince Bears leadership, once and for all, that they should move from Chicago to the northwest suburbs.

At times, such a decision has appeared imminent. More often, it feels far off. In 2023, two years after Arlington Park hosted its final horse race, the Bears bought the 326-acre property and demolished the iconic grandstand along with several other buildings. Since then, what was once known as Arlington International Racecourse has sat mostly undisturbed, fading history behind rusting locked gates. Desolation and an unending quiet has replaced the old roars of the track.

It had life, for a long time. Both Citation and Secretariat triumphed

Turn to Arlington, Page 4



A LIFE TAKEN AND WON BACK

Starting anew: The extraordinary journey of Jimmy Soto, who was exonerated after 42 years behind bars

By Madeline Buckley | Chicago Tribune

Around 8 p.m. at the notorious Stateville prison, Jimmy Soto was on the phone trying to get information about his court appearance the next day.

He was convicted of murder in 1982, but after decades of fighting, his appeal had momentum. Tomorrow could be the day he'd been waiting for. Or it could be another continuance. And anyone familiar with the ebb and flow of the hectic courthouse at 26th Street and California Avenue would not rule out yet another delay.

In the end, he went to bed with no clear answer. The phones shut down around 9 p.m. and the prison stilled.

It was Dec. 13, 2023, 12 days before Christmas. He had been incarcerated for 42 years.

But he would awake to good news. He rose around 5 a.m. and got one of the most momentous updates of his life from a neighbor.

"You're on TV," his fellow prisoner said. "You're going home today."

So at 62, James "Jimmy" Soto began the formidable work of starting his life once again.

Chicago has been called an epicenter of wrongful convictions by some defense attorneys and criminal justice-reform advocates. How to handle the avalanche of claims and the ensuing cost is a matter of concern and debate in the city and county halls of power.

More than two decades have passed since the infamous Chicago police Cmdr. Jon Burge was convicted of lying about systemic torture of suspects by him and a rogue crew of detectives, a matter that led to a state

torture commission to help evaluate the claims of coercion that followed. Other current and former Chicago Police Department investigators such as Reynaldo Guevara and Ronald Watts have been accused of wrongdoing, paving the way for a reexamination of practices by some police and prosecutors to close cases and win convictions.

In its wake, hundreds of convictions have been

Turn to Soto, Page 9

Local grocery taxes come as the state's go



Carol Flood, left, and her sister Judy Naper load grocery items after shopping at an Amazon Fresh on Dempster Street in Morton Grove on Friday. Morton Grove is one town that has recently approved a 1% grocery tax. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Municipalities adopt levies, even as food prices keep climbing

By Robert McCoppin and Molly Morrow
Chicago Tribune

Voters in Bensenville recently made clear how they felt about a proposed 1% tax on groceries. In a referendum on April 1, 91% voted against it.

Even though the measure failed in Bensenville, at least 163 communities around the state have recently enacted local grocery taxes.

Gov. JB Pritzker signed a bill last year repealing the state's 1% grocery tax, saying it hit poorer families harder. But the bill also allowed municipalities, which depend on the revenue, to imple-

ment their own tax. Bensenville put the proposal on the ballot to get voters' input, but local officials are not required to do so. In many municipalities, local governing bodies are casting the deciding vote.

The political hot potato promises to create a patchwork of taxes and has already led to finger-pointing between local and state officials. The debate over local grocery taxes also comes at a time when many consumers are worried about rising food prices.

"I don't like it, but I guess I kind of understand it," Jane Kramer, 73, said of the tax as she shopped for groceries in west suburban Batavia. "Yes, I'm disappointed about it, but that's our lives."

Other shoppers don't think a

Turn to Tax, Page 6

INSIDE



BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Counsel a villain in his hometown

A lot has changed in the Cubs manager's second season. But one thing hasn't: He is not well-liked in Milwaukee. **Chicago Sports**

Buffett to step down at the end of the year

The Berkshire Hathaway CEO recommended Greg Abel to serve as next leader, and warned of risk of global instability. **Nation & World**

